
SESSION 1B

SEEING MYSELF

SEEING MYSELF: WOE IS ME!

Isaiah explained it this way: “My eyes have seen the King, the LORD Almighty” (Isa. 6:5). He saw the holiness of God. For the first time in his life Isaiah really understood who God was. At the same instant, for the first time Isaiah really understood who Isaiah was.¹

- R.C. Sproul, *Holiness of God*

Once Isaiah saw the holiness of God, he saw himself clearly for the first time: as a sinner deserving “woe.” Isaiah, as a prophet, pronounces a curse upon himself, and declares himself “unclean.”

Notice that Isaiah does not respond to God's holiness with uplifted hands of praise, as appropriate as this would have been. But as R.C. Sproul notes, everyone in Scripture who encounters God's holiness responds first with a deep sense of personal sin. Seeing God immediately results in seeing ourselves in stark contrast to his holiness.

A very similar reaction is recorded about Peter's first encounter with the divinity of Jesus.



LUKE 5:4–10 (ESV)

⁴And when he had finished speaking, he said to Simon, “Put out into the deep and let down your nets for a catch.” ⁵And Simon answered, “Master, we toiled all night and took nothing! But at your word I will let down the nets.” ⁶And when they had done this, they enclosed a large number of fish, and their nets were breaking. ⁷They signaled to their partners in the other boat to come and help them. And they came and filled both the boats, so that they began to sink. ⁸But when Simon Peter saw it, he fell down at Jesus’ knees, saying, “Depart from me, for I am a sinful man, O Lord.” ⁹For he and all who were with him were astonished at the catch of fish that they had taken, ¹⁰and so also were James and John, sons of Zebedee, who were partners with Simon. And Jesus said to Simon, “Do not be afraid; from now on you will be catching men.”

¹ Sproul, R.C. (2008-08-18). *Holiness of God* (p. 30). Tyndale House Publishers, Inc. Kindle Edition.

Peter's response to Jesus parallels Isaiah's. He does not respond with: "Jesus, that was great. Can you come fishing with us every day?" His response is to recognize who Jesus is, and simultaneously who he is – a sinner. And just as Isaiah was commissioned as God's prophet upon seeing his sinfulness in the light of God's holiness, Peter, too, is commissioned as a fisher of men after he confesses, "Depart from me, for I am a sinful man, O Lord."

For Isaiah and Peter (and for all of us), they did not know themselves deeply until they saw themselves in the light of who God is.

A basic philosophical challenge is to "know thyself." "Who am I?" "What am I made of?" "What's really going on inside my heart?"—these questions are harder to answer than they should be. Surveys consistently show that we assess ourselves poorly, and that we consistently overrate ourselves.

We know if we're small or big because we calibrate ourselves. Smaller than an elephant, bigger than a fly. But what about morally and spiritually, where it really counts? How do you calibrate yourself?

On most days, most people feel fine about themselves. We have a hard time remembering anything we did wrong. We rate ourselves as above average in most things. The fact is we have faulty memories. For example, we do not notice when we were rude to someone, but clearly remember the times when we were slighted. Our memories and feelings are allied together to present to ourselves a very warped picture of ourselves.

Comparing ourselves to the general practices of others in our society doesn't get us anywhere closer to the truth either. Increasingly, people in our culture parade their folly and sins without shame. We feel like saints compared to the people of our world who are famous for having defaced all standards and live in utter degradation.

But is this the proper backdrop by which to see ourselves? What makes a stain ugly? It depends on what it's on. A ketchup stain on a picnic table is not great, but what if that same stain was on the painting of the Mona Lisa?

The proper backdrop cannot be other people. We know that there have been periods in which whole nations thought that they were righteous when they weren't: think pre-Civil War South, or Nazi Germany.

The only proper backdrop is the holiness of God. And the scriptural claim is that deep down we know this.



ROMANS 1:18-21 (ESV)

¹⁸For the wrath of God is revealed from heaven against all ungodliness and unrighteousness of men, who by their unrighteousness suppress the truth. ¹⁹For what can be known about God is plain to them, because God has shown it to them. ²⁰For his invisible attributes, namely, his eternal power and divine nature, have been clearly perceived, ever since the creation of the world, in the things that have been made. So they are without excuse. ²¹For

although they knew God, they did not honor him as God or give thanks to him, but they became futile in their thinking, and their foolish hearts were darkened.

The word of God says that people “suppress the truth” about God, resisting the knowledge of God because they do not want to “honor him as God.” This leads to their thinking becoming infected and their hearts becoming darkened.

Why is it that so many people can be proud and egotistical and feel no conviction of sin about it? Or be a selfish princess/prince and be shameless about it?

We're selfish to the core, and shamelessly so. Why? It's because we're so self-absorbed that we don't see the context. If you're self-absorbed, you are essentially a closed system. Whatever you are--whatever selfishness or sinfulness that you happen to be—it *just is*. If you are a closed system, then whatever you do, that *just is*. It is what it is. You don't know what to make of it. Increasingly, our society is isolating us in bizarre little closed worlds. With our earbuds in, and our eyes fixed on our small screen-world, we lack external referents to know how to weigh, evaluate, or think about the quality of our souls. So we are lost and afloat.

People are left to consult only themselves. They say things like, "I don't feel like I'm selfish. I don't feel like I did something bad." It's like a driver careening through the world crashing into things, but saying, "I feel like I'm a safe driver." Many people live in this kind of delusional bubble about their souls. They can manage to do so because they don't bump up against reality that will burst that bubble. No one around them tells them the truth. They only consult their own feelings.

Maybe you don't really want to see yourself. Maybe the truth about yourself does not interest you, because you have a sneaking suspicion that it will be painful. So you choose not to pursue this knowledge. You avoid self-criticism or reflection. You make yourself a stranger to yourself, blunt your own conscience, and refuse to tolerate any negative thoughts about yourself. You bounce your thoughts away from any sorrowful knowledge of your sinfulness, and quickly assuage yourself with kinder thoughts about yourself.

What are some ways you avoid seeing yourself?

THINKING HARD

...There are certain steps before one ever becomes a Christian, and the first is that a man has got to stop and think. I say it is impossible to be a Christian without thinking. ... Yet the whole case of the Bible is that a man does not even begin to become a Christian until he thinks. What does he think about? He thinks about himself. David had committed a terrible sin, a terrible crime. He was guilty of murder, he was guilty of adultery, and yet he went on as if he had done nothing at all. And he had to be pulled up by the prophet Nathan, who showed him what he had done and made him face himself. It was then realized what exactly he had done. That is always the first step. If you are a person who has not sat down and looked at himself, whatever else is true of you, I can tell you that you are not a Christian. It is impossible to be a Christian without facing yourself and looking at your own life. The world does its best to prevent us doing that. With its organized pleasures and all its suggestive attractions it is doing everything it can to prevent people sitting down and thinking and facing themselves and their own lives. But the man who is a Christian has passed all that. He has stopped and has looked, he has examined, he has recognized certain things about himself, he has made a certain confession. You will find that in the first verse of the psalm.²

- Martin Lloyd Jones, *Out of the Depths*

If you don't think, then what are you going to be left with? You're going to be left with your feelings, which is why people can say, "I feel I'm not a sinner." But of course you're not going to feel that you are a sinner until you've thought about it.

For the most part, we loathe this kind of thinking, and even if we try, our impossibly distracting lives make such sustained and painful thinking very difficult. So we are left with vague feelings about ourselves. And our feelings are our friends. Our feelings will accentuate wrongs done to us, or the ways we are victimized, or yank us around with cravings, frustrations, or anger. One thing our feelings will rarely do is give us a clear sense of who we are really. Most likely, the sum total of what we're going to feel is that we're the victim, the misunderstood, the underappreciated. We're the hero or heroine.

When was the last time you thought hard about yourself and tried to be painfully objective about what kind of person you really are?

THE TRUE GLIMPSE

Occasionally, even in the midst of the mundane, we can get a glimpse into something like an absolute standard.

² Lloyd-Jones, David Martin. *Out of the Depths: Restoring Fellowship with God*. Wheaton, Illinois: Crossway Books. 1995. pp. 67-68.

For example, you ridicule a friend in public until you see her face. When you see the sense of hurt and woundedness, then maybe, maybe you realize that your rude remarks, made only in furtherance of your own social standing, have hurt and betrayed another human being.

Or, say you make vulgar and cruel comments to a group of other guys about some unattractive feature of a woman's body as she passes by, until you look up and realize one of those guys is her dad. You see the love of that dad for his daughter manifest on his face in offended anger.

Then the horror strikes you. Against the backdrop of a father's love for his daughter, the true, objective nature of what you just did is revealed. The context delivers it home.

Or, you read about the horrors of human trafficking, of girls being lured away from villages to the big city, only to be abducted, and you get so, so angry. Against the backdrop of these girls sold into brothels or the porn industry, you understand your own sexual sins more accurately.

What is going on here? In the context of the love of family, or just basic human decency, the sin become exposed as ugly. You are given a very small glimpse into something like God's view of things.

Take this and multiply it a thousand-fold: we are not talking about the wounded heart of a loving dad, but the God of the universe, the perfectly holy and loving God who is goodness and holiness itself. Some people distinguish between God's holiness and love. But God is holy-love: he is holy in his love, and his great love and his holiness are one.

So, what is the proper context to see ourselves objectively? The fixed backdrop against which you can see the essence of your soul, the quality of your personhood?

The only context, the only proper backdrop is God's holy character. Instead of floating around un-calibrated, you finally have the right grid, the right perspective with which to see yourself. It is of the utmost importance that we see ourselves through the holiness of God. This shame, this cringing sense that I am a blemish on the pure moral canvas of his holy character brings out of us Isaiah's cry: "Woe is me, I am ruined."

Explain your personal experience of coming to see your sins against the backdrop of the holiness of God.